

CSS Border-Image Property

Complete Guide: Easy English Explanation

Contents

1	Introduction	2
1.1	What is Border-Image?	2
1.2	Why Use Border-Image?	2
1.3	How It Works	3
1.3.1	Standard Border	3
1.3.2	Border-Image	3
1.4	Key Concepts	3
1.4.1	Image Slicing	3
1.4.2	Border Width	3
2	Border-Image Components	4
2.1	The border-image-source Property	4
2.1.1	What It Does	4
2.1.2	Values	4
2.2	The border-image-slice Property	4
2.2.1	What It Does	4
2.2.2	How Slicing Works	5
2.3	The border-image-width Property	5
2.3.1	What It Does	5
2.3.2	Values	5
2.4	The border-image-repeat Property	5
2.4.1	What It Does	5
2.4.2	Repeat Values	6
2.5	The border-image-outset Property	6
2.5.1	What It Does	6
2.5.2	Values	6
3	The Border-Image Shorthand	7
3.1	Shorthand Syntax	7
3.2	Component Order	7
3.3	Shorthand Examples	7
4	Practical Examples	8
4.1	Example 1: Simple Decorative Frame	8
4.2	Example 2: Pixel Art Border	8
4.3	Example 3: Gradient Border	8
4.4	Example 4: Repeating Pattern Border	9

4.5	Example 5: Vintage Frame	9
4.6	Example 6: Border with Corners and Edges	9
4.7	Example 7: Thin Accent Border	10
4.8	Example 8: Multiple Borders with Images	10
4.9	Example 9: Animated Border Effect	10
4.10	Example 10: Rounded Corners with Border-Image	11
5	Understanding Image Slicing	12
5.1	Visual Slice Example	12
5.1.1	Image Grid	12
5.1.2	Slice Values	12
5.2	The fill Keyword	13
6	Repeat Modes Explained	14
6.1	stretch	14
6.2	repeat	14
6.3	round	14
6.4	space	15
7	Browser Support	16
7.1	Compatibility	16
7.2	Partial Support Notes	16
7.3	Vendor Prefix	16
8	Common Mistakes	17
8.1	Mistake 1: Forgetting Border Width	17
8.2	Mistake 2: Using border-image with border-radius	17
8.3	Mistake 3: Incorrect Slice Values	17
8.4	Mistake 4: Not Understanding fill	18
8.5	Mistake 5: Wrong Repeat Mode	18
9	Creating Border-Image Source Files	19
9.1	Image Requirements	19
9.1.1	Size	19
9.1.2	Format	19
9.2	Design Tips	19
10	Performance Considerations	20
10.1	Browser Rendering	20
10.2	Best Practices	20
11	Quick Reference	21
11.1	Border-Image Properties	21
11.2	Complete CSS Template	21
11.3	Repeat Mode Comparison	22
11.4	Decision Guide	22
11.5	Common Use Cases	22
11.6	Pro Tips	23
11.7	Remember	23

Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 What is Border-Image?

The `border-image` property allows you to use an image (instead of solid colors or patterns) to create decorative borders around an element. You can create unique, artistic borders by slicing an image and applying the pieces to the edges and corners of an element.

Think of border-image like framing a picture:

- **Standard border:** Solid color line around the edge
- **Border-image:** Custom graphic border with corners and edges

Border-image lets you create stunning custom borders using images!

1.2 Why Use Border-Image?

Border-image is useful for:

- Creating decorative frames and borders
- Unique UI element styling
- Professional design effects
- Ornamental border patterns
- Game-like UI elements
- Pixel art borders
- Custom frame designs
- Artistic visual effects
- Making designs stand out

1.3 How It Works

1.3.1 Standard Border

```
.box {  
  border: 10px solid red;  
  /* Simple solid color border */  
}
```

1.3.2 Border-Image

```
.box {  
  border: 10px solid;  
  border-image: url('frame.png') 30 stretch;  
  /* Uses image as border instead of color */  
}
```

1.4 Key Concepts

1.4.1 Image Slicing

Border-image divides the border image into 9 parts:

- 4 corners (unchanged)
- 4 edges (stretched/repeated)
- 1 center (usually not used)

1.4.2 Border Width

The border-width must be set for border-image to work:

```
.box {  
  border: 15px solid; /* Width must be set */  
  border-image: url('frame.png') 30;  
}
```

Chapter 2

Border-Image Components

2.1 The border-image-source Property

2.1.1 What It Does

Defines the image URL to use for the border.

```
.box {  
  border-image-source: url('border.png');  
  /* Can be: url(), gradient, or none */  
}
```

2.1.2 Values

- `url('path')` - Path to image file
- `url(data:...)` - Data URI
- `linear-gradient()` - CSS gradient
- `none` - No border image

2.2 The border-image-slice Property

2.2.1 What It Does

Defines how to slice the border image. Specifies the distances from the edges where the image is cut.

```
.box {  
  border-image-slice: 30;  
  /* 30px inset from each edge */  
}  
  
.box2 {  
  border-image-slice: 30 40 50 60;  
  /* Top, Right, Bottom, Left */  
}
```

```
.box3 {  
  border-image-slice: 30 fill;  
  /* 30px slice, and fill the center */  
}
```

2.2.2 How Slicing Works

The image is divided into a 3x3 grid:

- Slice value creates the grid divisions
- Each part of the grid becomes a piece
- Corners use the corner pieces (unchanged)
- Edges stretch or repeat to fit

2.3 The border-image-width Property

2.3.1 What It Does

Sets the width of the border-image. Overrides the border-width if specified separately.

```
.box {  
  border: 10px solid;  
  border-image-width: 15px;  
  /* Border will be 15px wide, not 10px */  
}
```

2.3.2 Values

- Pixel values: 15px
- Multiple values: 15px 20px 15px 20px
- Number (multiplier): 1.5 ($1.5 \times \text{border-width}$)
- auto - Uses border-image-slice value

2.4 The border-image-repeat Property

2.4.1 What It Does

Defines how edge pieces are repeated or stretched to fit the border.

```
.box {  
  border-image-repeat: stretch; /* Stretch edges */  
}  
  
.box2 {  
  border-image-repeat: repeat; /* Repeat pattern */  
}
```

```
.box3 {  
  border-image-repeat: round;    /* Repeat rounded */  
}  
  
.box4 {  
  border-image-repeat: space;    /* Space between repeats */  
}
```

2.4.2 Repeat Values

- **stretch** - Stretch edges to fit (default)
- **repeat** - Tile the pattern
- **round** - Tile and scale to fit exactly
- **space** - Tile with equal spacing

2.5 The border-image-outset Property

2.5.1 What It Does

Extends the border-image beyond the border box edge.

```
.box {  
  border-image-outset: 10px;  
  /* Border image extends 10px outside border box */  
}
```

2.5.2 Values

- Pixel values: 10px
- Multiple values: 10px 15px 10px 15px
- Number (multiplier): 1 ($1 \times$ border-width)

Chapter 3

The Border-Image Shorthand

3.1 Shorthand Syntax

```
border-image: source slice / width / outset repeat;  
  
/* Example */  
border-image: url('frame.png') 30 / 15px / 0 stretch;
```

3.2 Component Order

1. **source** - Image URL (required)
2. **slice** - How to slice (required)
3. **width** - Border width (optional, slash required)
4. **outset** - Extension (optional, slash required)
5. **repeat** - Repeat mode (optional)

3.3 Shorthand Examples

```
/* Minimal */  
border-image: url('frame.png') 30;  
  
/* With width */  
border-image: url('frame.png') 30 / 15px;  
  
/* Complete */  
border-image: url('frame.png') 30 / 15px / 5px stretch;  
  
/* With repeat */  
border-image: url('frame.png') 30 10 repeat;  
  
/* With fill and repeat */  
border-image: url('frame.png') 30 fill space;
```

Chapter 4

Practical Examples

4.1 Example 1: Simple Decorative Frame

```
.card {  
  width: 300px;  
  padding: 20px;  
  border: 15px solid;  
  border-image: url('gold-frame.png') 30 stretch;  
  background: white;  
}  
  
/*  
Creates a card with ornate gold border frame  
using an image as the border decoration  
*/
```

4.2 Example 2: Pixel Art Border

```
.game-ui {  
  padding: 16px;  
  border: 8px solid;  
  border-image: url('pixel-border.png') 8 repeat;  
  background: #222;  
  color: white;  
}  
  
/*  
Creates a retro game-like UI with tiled  
pixel art border pattern  
*/
```

4.3 Example 3: Gradient Border

```
.gradient-border {  
  padding: 20px;
```

```
border: 3px solid;
border-image: linear-gradient(45deg,
                              #667eea,
                              #764ba2,
                              #f093fb)
              1 stretch;
}

/*
Creates a gradient border using CSS gradient
as the border-image source
*/
```

4.4 Example 4: Repeating Pattern Border

```
.patterned-box {
  width: 250px;
  padding: 15px;
  border: 12px solid;
  border-image: url('pattern.png') 20 repeat;
  background: #f9f9f9;
}

/*
Border pattern repeats around all four sides
*/
```

4.5 Example 5: Vintage Frame

```
.vintage-frame {
  border: 25px solid;
  border-image: url('vintage-frame.png')
               50 25 50 25
               / 25px
               stretch;
  padding: 20px;
  background: white;
}

/*
Creates a vintage/ornate frame look
with different top and bottom emphasis
*/
```

4.6 Example 6: Border with Corners and Edges

```
.corner-frame {
  width: 300px;
```

```
height: 200px;
padding: 20px;
border: 20px solid;
border-image: url('frame-with-corners.png')
              40 / 20px
              stretch;
background: #fff;
box-shadow: 0 4px 6px rgba(0,0,0,0.1);
}

/*
Image includes decorative corner elements
that appear at the corners of the border
*/
```

4.7 Example 7: Thin Accent Border

```
.accent-border {
padding: 12px;
border: 3px solid;
border-image: url('accent.png') 10 stretch;
font-weight: bold;
color: #333;
}

/*
Thin decorative border accent
for buttons, headings, or highlights
*/
```

4.8 Example 8: Multiple Borders with Images

```
.double-frame {
border: 15px solid;
border-image: url('outer-frame.png') 30 stretch;
outline: 5px solid;
outline-offset: -10px;
background: white;
padding: 20px;
}

/*
Combines border-image with outline
for layered border effect
*/
```

4.9 Example 9: Animated Border Effect

```
.animated-border {
  border: 10px solid;
  border-image: url('glow.png') 20 stretch;
  padding: 20px;
  transition: border-width 0.3s;
}

.animated-border:hover {
  border-width: 15px;
  border-image: url('glow-bright.png') 30 stretch;
}

/*
Changes border-image on hover for effect
*/
```

4.10 Example 10: Rounded Corners with Border-Image

```
.rounded-frame {
  border: 20px solid;
  border-image: url('rounded-frame.png')
               40 / 20px
               stretch;
  border-radius: 15px;
  padding: 20px;
  background: white;
}

/*
Combines border-image with border-radius
Creates rounded decorative frame
Note: border-image takes precedence
*/
```

Chapter 5

Understanding Image Slicing

5.1 Visual Slice Example

5.1.1 Image Grid

A border-image source is divided into 9 parts:

Slice value: 30

Corner Top-L	Top Edge	Corner Top-R	(1) (2) (3)
Left Edge	Center	Right Edge	(4) (5) (6)
Corner Bottom-L	Bottom Edge	Corner Bottom-R	(7) (8) (9)

Pieces 1,3,7,9: Corners (used as-is)

Pieces 2,4,6,8: Edges (stretched/repeated)

Piece 5: Center (ignored)

5.1.2 Slice Values

```
/* All sides equal */
border-image-slice: 30;

/* Top/Bottom, Left/Right */
border-image-slice: 30 40;

/* Top, Left/Right, Bottom */
border-image-slice: 30 40 50;

/* Top, Right, Bottom, Left */
border-image-slice: 30 40 50 60;

/* With fill to include center */
```

```
border-image-slice: 30 fill;
```

5.2 The fill Keyword

By default, the center piece is not used. Add `fill` to include it:

```
/* Without fill - center is transparent */  
border-image-slice: 30;  
  
/* With fill - center is visible */  
border-image-slice: 30 fill;
```

Chapter 6

Repeat Modes Explained

6.1 stretch

Edges stretch to fit the border.

```
border-image-repeat: stretch;

/*
Edge pieces are scaled/stretched
to exactly fill the border space
Result: Single stretched edge
*/
```

6.2 repeat

Edge pattern repeats/tiles.

```
border-image-repeat: repeat;

/*
Edge pieces are tiled repeatedly
Pattern may be cut off at corners
Result: Repeated pattern
*/
```

6.3 round

Pattern repeats and scales to fit exactly.

```
border-image-repeat: round;

/*
Pattern tiles and scales so it fits perfectly
No partial pieces shown
Result: Evenly-spaced complete patterns
*/
```


6.4 space

Pattern repeats with equal spacing.

```
border-image-repeat: space;

/*
Pattern repeats with equal space between
Fills available space evenly
Result: Spaced-out patterns
*/
```

Chapter 7

Browser Support

7.1 Compatibility

Border-image is well-supported in all modern browsers:

- Chrome 15+
- Firefox 15+
- Safari 6+
- Edge (all versions)
- Opera 15+
- iOS Safari 6+
- Chrome Mobile 18+
- IE 11 (partial support)

7.2 Partial Support Notes

- IE 11: Doesn't support gradients as border-image
- Older Safari: May need -webkit- prefix
- Some mobile browsers: Limited gradient support

7.3 Vendor Prefix

Generally not needed, but for compatibility:

```
.box {  
  -webkit-border-image: url('frame.png') 30 stretch;  
  border-image: url('frame.png') 30 stretch;  
}
```

Chapter 8

Common Mistakes

8.1 Mistake 1: Forgetting Border Width

Wrong:

```
.box {  
  border-image: url('frame.png') 30;  
  /* No border width set! */  
}
```

Correct:

```
.box {  
  border: 15px solid; /* Width required */  
  border-image: url('frame.png') 30;  
}
```

8.2 Mistake 2: Using border-image with border-radius

Unexpected behavior:

```
.box {  
  border: 15px solid;  
  border-image: url('frame.png') 30 stretch;  
  border-radius: 10px;  
  /* Border-image ignores border-radius! */  
}
```

Note: Border-image does not respect border-radius. Corners will be square regardless.

8.3 Mistake 3: Incorrect Slice Values

Problem:

```
.box {  
  border-image: url('frame.png') 100;  
  /* Slicing 100px from a 50px wide image! */  
}
```

Solution: Slice values should match your image dimensions.

8.4 Mistake 4: Not Understanding fill

Confusing:

```
.box {  
  border-image: url('frame.png') 30;  
  /* Center area is transparent */  
}  
  
.box2 {  
  border-image: url('frame.png') 30 fill;  
  /* Center area shows the image content */  
}
```

8.5 Mistake 5: Wrong Repeat Mode

Unexpected result:

```
.box {  
  border-image: url('pattern.png') 20 repeat;  
  /* Pattern cuts off at corners - looks bad */  
}  
  
/* Better: */  
.box {  
  border-image: url('pattern.png') 20 round;  
  /* Pattern scales to fit perfectly */  
}
```

Chapter 9

Creating Border-Image Source Files

9.1 Image Requirements

9.1.1 Size

For best results, make your border-image source:

- At least 60×60 pixels (for slicing)
- Square or rectangular
- Proportionate to your slice values

9.1.2 Format

- PNG (recommended - transparency support)
- JPG (no transparency)
- SVG (scalable)
- GIF (animated possible)

9.2 Design Tips

- Design symmetrical frames for consistency
- Use clear corner elements for corners
- Make edge patterns tile smoothly
- Test at different border widths
- Consider light and dark backgrounds
- Optimize file size (images add overhead)

Chapter 10

Performance Considerations

10.1 Browser Rendering

- Border-image is GPU-accelerated
- Similar performance to regular borders
- No significant performance penalty
- Large images may impact performance
- Gradients are faster than image files

10.2 Best Practices

1. Use optimized/compressed images
2. Consider SVG for scalability
3. Limit number of border-image elements
4. Use CSS gradients when possible (lighter)
5. Cache border-image resources
6. Test on lower-end devices

Chapter 11

Quick Reference

11.1 Border-Image Properties

Property	Purpose
border-image	Shorthand for all border-image props
border-image-source	Image URL or gradient
border-image-slice	How to slice the image
border-image-width	Border width
border-image-repeat	How to repeat edges
border-image-outset	Extend beyond border box

11.2 Complete CSS Template

```
/* Simple border-image */
.frame-simple {
  border: 15px solid;
  border-image: url('frame.png') 30 stretch;
  padding: 20px;
}

/* Advanced border-image */
.frame-advanced {
  border: 20px solid;
  border-image: url('frame.png')
                40 / 20px / 10px
                round;
  padding: 20px;
}

/* Gradient border-image */
.frame-gradient {
  border: 5px solid;
  border-image: linear-gradient(45deg,
                                #667eea,
                                #764ba2)
                1 stretch;
  padding: 20px;
}
```

11.3 Repeat Mode Comparison

Mode	Result
stretch	Single stretched edge
repeat	Tiled pattern (may cut off)
round	Tiled pattern (scales to fit)
space	Tiled with equal spacing

11.4 Decision Guide

1. Do you need an image border?
 - NO → Use regular border property
 - YES → Continue
2. Do you have corners and edges?
 - YES → Slice appropriately
 - NO → Use smaller slice
3. Should edges repeat?
 - Stretch → Use **stretch**
 - Repeat → Use **repeat** or **round**

11.5 Common Use Cases

- Ornate decorative frames
- Game UI borders
- Card styling
- Photo frames
- Pixel art borders
- Vintage-style borders
- Gradient decorative borders
- Custom button borders
- Panel/section frames
- Interactive element borders

11.6 Pro Tips

1. Use CSS gradients for lighter performance
2. Test repeat modes with your image
3. Remember border-radius doesn't work with border-image
4. Optimize image files before using
5. Consider fallback for older browsers
6. Use consistent slice values across related elements
7. Document your slice values in CSS comments
8. Test on different screen sizes

11.7 Remember

- Border-width **MUST** be set
- Border-radius is ignored
- Slice values should match image dimensions
- Choose repeat mode based on pattern
- Gradients are valid border-image sources
- Fill keyword includes center area
- Outset extends beyond border box
- Performance is good for reasonable-sized images